

Episode 170: Emergency Investigation! Are Directors Popular?

The days called intense heat and extreme heat have become distant, settling into quite bearable temperature days. Our house neighbours a park, and the cicadas' voices that had been noisily crying from sunrise to midnight have gradually decreased, replaced by gentle cricket and autumn insect voices.

Ah, summer is leaving.

Before summer came, my plans were to resume mountain hiking after several years, camp and eat barbecue at Kiso-Komagatake in midsummer, climb Mount Fuji this year! - such thoughts, but when summer actually came, intensely busy *Mawaru Penguindrum* days. Summer is ending without much opportunity for summer-like activities.

Mountain barbecue didn't happen, but I was fulfilled this summer. Being able to concentrate on beloved work so seamlessly, having *Mawaru Penguindrum* - a work I worked hard on with many colleagues - get off to a highly acclaimed start became this summer's greatest memory above all. 2011's 48-year-old summer is leaving, but when I look back someday, I have a feeling it will be an unforgettable summer.

Now, production is finally entering the latter half's second cour. Three more months - let's run!

Anyway.

Recently, young actor Nakao Akiyoshi appeared on a Sunday afternoon Fuji TV programmes, and I happened to watch, thinking "huh? This person resembles someone?" "Ah! That's right! *PreCure's* Otsuka-kun!" That's right. Director Otsuka Takashi closely resembles this Nakao Akiyoshi-kun. Well, a handsome man.

Tweeting about such things, the person himself got hooked - ah, Otsuka-kun's side (laugh). From "is Otsuka-kun popular?" the topic somehow became "are directors popular?"

"Eh? Directors are popular, right?" I said. "Eh? That's not true," said Otsuka-kun. "Look at me and Nagamine-san" (laugh). Well, setting aside Nagamine-kun (explosion), I have an image that people with "director" titles are popular... Then Director Sato Jun'ichi said:

"My 30 years of physical surveys confirm no relationship between job type and popularity!"

Ugh! 30 years is heavy! (laugh) But Sato-san seems plenty popular to me?

The word "director" has an image of someone who judges various things, leads everyone, and bears responsibility as a solid existence. Some aura feeling, such special feeling. Well naturally, individual qualities are questioned, but people in "director" positions seem to have that human weight, that "ah, right!" quality that convinces everyone around them.

Well, don't you think the word "director" is cool? (laugh)

Looking around, our animation industry has truly many "directors" even within making one work.

Starting with "director" at the top (oh, there's also "general director"), animation director, art director, photography director, CG director or VFX director, sound director, music director, etc. Each section has respective "directors." Among those, wait? Our finishing department has no position called director. "Colour design" (色彩設計), "colour direction" (色指定), "inspection" - but not "director." ...Ah, I think I remember seeing "finishing director" credit somewhere before, but generally current production systems don't have "finishing director" credits.

Hmm, why is that?

For example, if it's art staff, finished backgrounds are final-checked by "art director" before passing to photography, right? Same with animation - rough animation only goes to in-betweening after "animation director" checks and approves. Photography staff also have finished rushes approved by "photography director" before editing. In other words, respective "directors" are positioned to manage and supervise the qualitative aspects of their section's products.

Our finishing section is composed of colour design → colour direction → colouring → finishing inspection flow, and usually colouring data passed to photography is ultimately checked by finishing inspection staff before being passed to photography.

Are "director" positions those who bundle everything together to become "director"? Thinking about it, does "finishing" not have "directors" because it's an assembly line system that asks final staff for checks? Or changing perspective, are finishing inspection staff closer to "directors"? Maybe, but that also feels somewhat different.

So what is our finishing section's "quality"? The absolutely important thing is properly fulfilling requirements as photography materials. Not just colouring data precision like size and colour mistakes, but whether mask materials are properly complete - naturally important points. Regarding this, it's "colouring" and "finishing inspection," and also "colour" problems. I think this part is "colour design" and "colour direction." Finishing "quality" consists of both.

Certainly "colour design" is positioned at the beginning of finishing work flow and somewhat oversees the finishing section generally, but still feels different from "director" positions somehow. Even so, for works where I handle colour design, I try to control from the front as much as possible.

I'm entrusted with selecting main colour direction staff, and request colour direction staff handle finishing inspection themselves. Rushes checks, retake assignments, and final retake processing are handled together with colour direction staff. Working together as a small group like this makes communication smooth and enables sharing series-wide work recognition. Then "quality" can naturally be maintained.

If such creation methods are possible, I think "finishing director" is unnecessary for works I'm involved with (laugh).

Now, the "are directors popular?" problem. An important statement emerges here.

"Character designers seem popular!"

"Character design" is more popular than directors! Ah, I somehow understand... So are "directors who also do character design" strongest? There are quite a few such people, right? Among my acquaintances, maybe Oizaki Fumitoshi-san? How is it really? How about it, Oizaki-san!

...The truth of that matter is for another time (laugh).

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